



How to Build an AI Product Team

1. Stages and Hiring Gates

Role \ Stage	Early	Middle	Later
Full-Stack Engineer			
Data Scientist/Data Analyst			
Product Manager			
Product Designer*			
AI Infra / Platform			
ML Engineer			

Start centralized to concentrate scarce expertise and build **shared infra and evaluators**. As product teams adopt a common platform, **embed AI into each product team** while keeping a lean platform team for tooling, eval suites, and governance.

Bryan Bischof for The Product Compass Newsletter

2. How to Interview AI Team Members

a. The Hiring Thesis

Define: **why this role, why now**, why not someone already on the team?

Role \ Stage	Early	Middle	Later
Full-Stack Engineer	Ship the first vertical slice, add basic logging, safe fallbacks	Harden endpoints, add structured telemetry for evals, basic cost controls	Performance tuning, rate-limits, rollout guards
Data Scientist/Data Analyst	Drive evals, weekly traces review, failure taxonomy	Drive segmenting failure modes, binary checks in CI or pre-release gates	Own dashboards for quality, drift, and experiment results
Product Manager	User value and business viability risks	Define KPIs, e.g., by user journey	Sequence experiments by ROI and risk
Product Designer	Reduce "AI confusion", tackle the usability risk, work closely with a PM	Dialogue patterns, explanation flows, learnable controls	Guardrails in UX, explainability patterns for high-stakes flows
AI Infra / Platform	-	Observability, eval infrastructure, shared data pipelines	Test gates in CI, shared tools, governance, incident playbooks
ML Engineer	-	-	Fine-tuning, custom pipelines, safety and robustness experiments

b. Expect Roles to Blur

The collaboration is **even closer** than in traditional products, e.g.:

- PM reviews traces with data scientist and domain experts.
- Product designer experiments with vibe-engineering tools.
- Engineers deepen domain expertise to interpret outputs and suggest solutions.

The **key trait is curiosity**. Also, screen hard for: data intuition, product sense, and urgency.

c. Test for AI Thinking

Skip **theory trivia**. Use hands-on exercises. For example:

- Give a small, messy slice from evals or user logs.
- Ask to review traces, identify failure modes, and propose evaluators.
- Ask to design the smallest agent. Discuss observability, guardrails, evals, etc.

What matters is how candidates reason, collaborate, use judgement and adapt in **ambiguous problem spaces**.